

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Distinguished"

Ārya Viśiṣṭavatī Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 872 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Distinguished" (Sanskrit: Ārya Viśiṣṭavatī Nāma Dhāraṇī; Tibetan: Phagpa Khyepar Chen zhé jawé Zung) is a short scriptural text of the dhāraṇī type, a genre built around protective or empowering formulas of sacred speech. It opens in the manner of a sūtra, with the standard "Thus did I hear at one time," and situates the Buddha in a temple in a town called Sañco in the Land of Doves, where a monk named Tsejö, traveling on business, encounters a man of enormous size whom he takes to be the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī. The narrative frame leads into the teaching and recitation of the dhāraṇī itself, together with the benefits promised to those who uphold it. The text is Toh 872 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of translated words of the Buddha, and it belongs to the Tantra division, where dhāraṇīs of this kind are gathered.

In the language of India: Ārya Viśiṣṭavatī Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Distinguished."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. In the year of the snake, on the twentieth day of the first winter month, the Blessed One was staying in a temple in the town called Sañco, in the Land of Doves. At that time a monk named Tsejö went on some business to a town called Nesong. When that monk had travelled a road of a hundred leagues from a city in China, he saw there, from a great distance, a man of enormous body, thirty spans tall, with a face four spans across.

On seeing him, the monk Tsejö thought this about such a man: "Ah, this man's body is huge! He must certainly be Mañjuśrī, the Youthful." Thinking this, he set both kneecaps on the ground, joined his palms, and bowed toward where the man of enormous body stood. Then he spoke these words to him: "Are you Mañjuśrī, the Youthful? Are you here?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Monk, it is so."

The monk said, "Mañjuśrī, why are you here?"

Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, said: "Monk, here in Jambudvīpa many kinds of disease are arising among sentient beings. Yakṣas, asuras, garuḍas, and gandharvas are dwelling on one face of Mount Meru, king of mountains. Because of this the

light of the sun and moon cannot be seen; the sun, the moon, the planets, and the constellations do not appear in the expanse of the sky. At that time the gods and the asuras also wage war, and when the battle is joined, the gods are defeated and the asuras are victorious.

"At that time bhūtas and hungry ghosts, taking the form of women, send diseases upon sentient beings. They bring about swellings of the throat, pox, erysipelas, stomach pains, fevers that recur every day, every second day, every third day, and every fourth day, disorders arising from wind, from bile, from phlegm, and from their combination, headaches, blisters, itching, fevers, eye diseases, and the like. With heavy rains, drought, and untimely rains they rob the abundant harvest that is to come. They rob sentient beings of their vitality. They rob them of life, strength, complexion, and form. At that time all sentient beings in Jambudvīpa are thoroughly afflicted by various diseases.

"In the fierce forms of lions, wolves, tigers, snakes, and the like, they rob sentient beings of their vitality. Because they stand ready to bring untimely ruin upon the beings of Jambudvīpa, it is hard to free beings from disease. Here in Jambudvīpa, among old, middle-aged, and young beings, thirty vast multitudes are going to die.

"For this reason I have come to you, monk. You must proclaim this Dharma discourse to all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. Why is that? Because all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa hope, thinking, 'How may we be freed from all the bonds of suffering?'

"Therefore, monk, proclaim this sūtra to all sentient beings, and be earnest in it so that wholesome roots may grow in all sentient beings. Have constant, unbroken faith in the Three Jewels. Keep the deities in mind. Make offerings of fragrances, flowers, and incense to the stūpas and images of the Tathāgatas. Recite also the Dhāraṇī of the Distinguished. For seven days, keep the restoration observance with its eight branches.

"Homage to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata King Proclaiming the Thunder of Vast and Profound Intelligence.

Tadyathā: vipulagarjite, vipulasvare, vipulayoniśe, analase, analasaṃbhave, analasagatiṃgate svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Dispeller of All Obscurations.

Tadyathā: hema hema, hama hama svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Amitābha.

Tadyathā: amitodbhave, amitasamḃhave, amitavikrānte, amitavikrāntikare, amitagaganakīrtikare svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Source of Qualities.

Tadyathā: gagana-ākara, gaganasamḃhave, gaganakīrtikare svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Supreme Fragrance on Every Side.

Tadyathā: samasame svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Who Goes with Thundering Proclamation Through the Banner Unconquerable by Others.

Tadyathā: asamasame svāhā.

"Homage to the Tathāgata Subduer of Pride.

Tadyathā: manaviśuddhe, padmeśvare, padmasamḃhave, kiṃkare, hitaṃkarīye svāhā.

"Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. Homage to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, Dispeller of All Obscurations.

Tadyathā: śvetakarabhi, jvaline svāhā. Jaṃbhane, staṃbhane, mohane svāhā. Pauṇḍarīkāya svāhā. Home dharme, dharmācintrayai svāhā. Dhare bhidhare, kalapiṅkarutāyai svāhā. Śānte, kīṇne, nirvāpaṇye svāhā. Dhuru dhuru, vidurudhiye svāhā. Vimalapracundhāyai svāhā. Avalokita, vilokitāyai svāhā. Ājñānyavidhamanyai svāhā. Padmasvare, padmasamḃhave, kiṃkare hitaṃkarīye svāhā.

"Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Tadyathā: candraprabhe, candanagarbhe, candanacūrṇe, kekailasavati, sarvabuddha adhiṣṭhita anumodite svāhā.

"Homage to the noble bodhisattva Mañjuśrī.

Tadyathā: jaye jeye, jayalabhe, jayamahāmahe svāhā.

"Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Tadyathā: gagana-arye, gaganasamudgate, gaganavikrānta, vikrānte, eji meji, padmoji svāhā.

"Homage to the bodhisattva Samantabhadra.

tadyathā he bhadre mahābhadre atibhadre samantabhadre vigatarajase mahāvīgatarajase ativīgatarajase hemavati karmāvaraṇaviśodhane svāhā.

Homage to the noble bodhisattva Maitreya!

tadyathā maitri maitri maitrimanase svāhā.

Homage to the noble bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha!

tadyathā garbhe garbhe garbhe garbhaviśodhane svāhā.

Homage to the noble bodhisattva Akṣayamati!

tadyathā akṣaye nu akṣaye phu akṣayakarmaviśodhane phu svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva Vimalakīrti!

tadyathā kīrtitā sarvajinaiḥ abhikīrtita sarvajinaiḥ vajrākare vajrasaṃbhava
vajravedākare svāhā.

Homage to the bodhisattva Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin!

tadyathā sarvāvaraṇaviṣkambhinai svāhā. dhātuvikarāṇyai svāhā.
meghavisphoṭame svāhā. aparājita kāyai svāhā. baladadanyai svāhā.
bodhyaṃdadanyai svāhā. karmanirbhāvitakāyai svāhā. ekārāmāyai svāhā.
yogācārāyai svāhā. sarvabuddhābhiṣiktāyai svāhā. prahmopakutāyai svāhā.
sarvadharmābhiṣiktāyai svāhā. sarvabuddhābhiṣiktāyai svāhā. ekaśṛṅgāyai
svāhā. aśṛṅgāyai svāhā. bhūtāyai svāhā. asaṃbhūtāyai svāhā.
sarvaduḥkhopraśamanyai svāhā.

Homage to the youthful Candraprabha!

tadyathā candraprabhe suprabhe prabhākare prabhodgate prabhodgate
prabhavati prabhavati dharmaviśuddhe karmaviśuddhir bhavatu me svāhā.

Proclaimer of Life, suppose someone recites this vidyā-mantra for seven days,
seven times each day and seven times each night. All of their karmic
obscurations will then be completely purified, without exception. They should
give food to seven monks. They should kindle flame from flame. At night,
carrying lamps, they should respectfully circumambulate a stūpa. They should
apply themselves to copying and reading the sacred Dharma.

If a great epidemic breaks out, offerings should be made from house to house,
from village to village, and from town to town. They should be made with
gandharasa incense, tormas, and food offerings for the gods. If whoever is sick
also performs the rite in this way, they will quickly be freed from the illness.

Then Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, spoke further to the monk Proclaimer of Life:
"Monk, a son or daughter of good family may uphold this Dharma discourse,
read it, write it down, have it written down, or also teach it correctly and
extensively to others. Whoever does so will become irreversible from
unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening."

Again Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, spoke to the monk Proclaimer of Life: "This Dharma discourse should be sent from land to land, from town to town, and from village to village, so that it resounds in the ears of all people."

Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, spoke to the monk Proclaimer of Life: "Proclaimer of Life, if any son or daughter of good family reads this Dharma discourse once, they themselves will be liberated. Whoever reads it twice will be liberated together with their children and spouse. Whoever reads it three times will be liberated together with their household dependents. Whoever reads it four times, the whole surrounding country will also be liberated. Whoever reads it five times will be liberated together with the neighboring kings."

Again Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, spoke to the monk Proclaimer of Life: "This Dharma discourse should quickly be sent to other lands, so that these same benefits will arise there as well."

"Proclaimer of Life, some may hear this Dharma discourse and yet fail to act on it. They may not uphold it, read it, write it down, or have it written down. They may not master it, or teach it correctly and extensively to others. They may not send it out to other lands, or listen to it in common with all sentient beings. They may not fully dedicate it to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Whoever fails in this way will be reborn into a destiny just like that of those who commit the five acts of immediate retribution, and will be reproached by all the buddhas and bodhisattvas."

Again Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, spoke to the monk Proclaimer of Life: "Proclaimer of Life, whoever does not take this as authoritative is not one in whom I first instilled faith. Now, so that all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa may be happy, I shall go to Mount Meru, the king of mountains. There I shall strive to bring the gods and gandharvas into accord with the teaching."

Having spoken thus, Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, vanished from that very spot. The monk Proclaimer of Life rejoiced in what Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, had said, took it to heart, and departed.

This completes the noble dhāraṇī called The Distinguished.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé. It was also revised and finalized according to the new language standard.

Translator's Notes

- This text appears to be of Chinese origin. The Tibetan names a city "in China" and dates the event by the Chinese zodiac. The place and personal names do not clearly correspond to any Indian names. "The Land of Doves" translates the Tibetan phug ron can literally. "Sañco," "Nesong," and the monk's name "Tsejö" are given as transliterations, since their originals are uncertain. The numerical unit dkrigs phrag, rendered here as "thirty vast multitudes," denotes an enormous number whose exact value is unclear. The phrase lha rjed cig literally reads "forget the deities." It has been rendered "keep the deities in mind," on the assumption that a negation was lost or that a verb such as "remember" was intended. The mantras are given in Romanized Sanskrit as transmitted, and their spellings are often irregular. The Tibetan reads "candra na garbhe" and "candra na cūrṇe"; these are given here as candanagarbhe and candanacūrṇe.
- The monk's name, Tshe brjod, could not be securely identified with a Sanskrit form, so it is rendered literally as "Proclaimer of Life." The name list for this text shows a sound-spelling, "Tsejö," for this monk. If that form was used in the first piece, the two pieces should be harmonized. The literal rendering is kept here because house rules discourage Tibetan sound-spellings for names. The verb byab pa in the recitation instruction is taken as "recite," in line with the parallel ritual context. Mantras are transliterated as given in the Tibetan, with minimal normalization.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.